

REASON: A MISSING LINK

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Division among mankind is far from uncommon, especially with regards to his standing in Nature. C.S. Lewis, in Chapters II and III of his book *Miracles*, highlights a prominent example of such a division, namely, the disagreement between Naturalists and Supernaturalists. His aim in this excerpt is to consider a difficulty which plagues Naturalism, challenging the coherence and implications of this philosophy. This paper will first explore how Lewis constructs his intriguing philosophy, particularly his use of the somewhat puzzling Ground-Consequent and Cause-Effect *because* relations. It will then shift to unpacking these key concepts and explaining their connection to John McDowell's views, a more contemporary philosopher.

For Lewis, Naturalists are people who “believe that nothing exists except Nature.”¹ The Supernaturalist believes that, “besides Nature, there exists something else” (Lewis, p. 5). Lewis further distinguishes these terms in Chapter II by describing Supernaturalism as a more monarchical approach, whereby all of Nature is derivative from the “One Self-existent Thing,” or, God (Lewis, p. 7-8). He describes Naturalism as a democratic philosophy which acts in accordance with what he calls the “Total Event” (Lewis, p. 6-7). This can be understood by examining the turn of phrase: “A chain is only as strong as its weakest link.” For the Naturalist, every event is subject to the “Total Event” and even the smallest rupture in the chain renders it useless. With this in mind, Lewis argues that there is such a break in the chain, and that this break necessarily reduces Naturalist philosophy to no more than a pile of scrap metal. Reasoning, he says, cannot be confined to Naturalist explanation as this would require it to be characterized as just another link in the chain, connected to the prior links in the same way which it connects to all the rest. He goes on to set reasoning apart from the other links by stating that all human knowledge must come through sensation and inference and is contingent upon the validity of said reasoning (Lewis, 14). For example, I observe a great deal of four-legged hippopotami at the local zoo and infer by reason that four-leggedness is a general characteristic of hippopotami. Everything we know and, by extension, every belief we have or argument we make must be grounded in reason (Lewis, 14). Lewis essentially makes the claim that Naturalists cannot properly account for the reliability of reason solely according to their philosophy and, consequently, this is a shot in the foot since their philosophy unquestionably requires the use of this very tool (reason) for which they have no adequate account.

¹ C. S. Lewis, *Miracles*, 2nd edition (New York: Macmillan Publishing Company, 1960), p. 5.

To break this down further, Lewis categorizes the Naturalist description of events as one which must follow a Cause-Effect *modus operandi* (Lewis, p. 16). A subsequent link can be added to the chain *because* there is a previous link to which it can be fastened. To show that reasoning, according to the kind of thing that it is, cannot be categorized by this Cause-Effect *because*, we must examine another route. Here, Lewis introduces a second *because* which he terms the Ground-Consequent *because* (Lewis, p. 15). This description is key to distinguishing “a dynamic connection between events” from “a logical relation between beliefs or assertions” (Lewis, 15). The latter logical relation (the Ground-Consequent *because*) does not necessitate the Naturalist’s proposed “Total System” viewpoint, but rather, refers to a logical relation such as this: I must be gloomy *because* I lost my keys this morning. This example describes a belief, based in reason, which consequently produces the thought. I am not, as Naturalism purports, gloomy *because* Abraham Lincoln was shot in 1865, nor *because* I woke up on the wrong side of the bed this morning nor on account of any other mindlessly occurring event for that matter. Furthermore, if these events occur mindlessly, there is no need “to consider grounds for something which can be fully explained without them” (Lewis, 16). This key point underscores the necessity of distinguishing between the two kinds of *because*. For the Naturalist, regardless of whether or not my belief is correct, it occurs in cause-effect fashion according to the “Total System” quite distinctly from the actual grounding of logical premises which lead to these very beliefs. Now we can properly argue that reason’s ground-consequent essence simply cannot be permitted by a system which follows a line of reasoning based solely upon cause and effect.

I will now endeavor to compare how the two kinds of *because* relate to the views of a more recent philosopher, John McDowell. McDowell suggests a contrast between viewing thinking and knowing processes in light of the Sellarsian “logical space of reasons” as opposed to a view based on the laws of nature and physics.² This can be likened to Lewis’s distinction between the Ground-Consequent *because* and the Cause-Effect *because* respectively. McDowell uses a modified version of Wilfred Sellars’s term “space of reasons” as a way of describing our thoughts and beliefs as rationally interconnected in our conceptual framework and justifiable according to said reason (McDowell, p. 257). This closely parallels Lewis’s Ground-Consequent *because*, the idea that our thoughts and beliefs are a consequence of some logical ground.

² McDowell, John. *Naturalism in the Philosophy of Mind*. In *Naturalism in Question*, edited by Robert B. Brandom. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2008, p. 258.

Similarly, McDowell's explanation of the laws of nature and physics as a means for describing the processes of human reasoning can be likened to Lewis's Cause-Effect *because*, which claims that everything in nature is explicable in terms of the Total System. Referring to the laws of physics and nature, McDowell states that "on its own this body of truth cannot incorporate the bearing of mental states on objective reality. But it is the whole of part of the truth about the mental" (McDowell, p. 266). Lewis, commenting on the implications of describing reason according to Naturalist philosophy, states that "in order for a train of thought to have any value, these two systems of connection must apply simultaneously to the same series of mental acts" (Lewis, p. 16). Here, Lewis touches on a way that one might try to account for reason from Naturalist premises, a proposal which McDowell attempts to draw out in his article. McDowell takes issue with and proposes an alternative solution to Modern Epistemology's felt "obligation to reconnect the knowing subject with a natural world from which it seems to have withdrawn." (McDowell, p. 259) The two authors, grappling with these similar concepts, come to very different conclusions. Lewis, trying to demonstrate the great difficulty of Naturalism, recognizes the need for both kinds of *because* in human understanding but states that, when categorizing our processes of reasoning, "unfortunately the two systems are wholly distinct." (Lewis, p. 16) Whereas Lewis is clear in defining Naturalism's alternative, Supernaturalism, McDowell is careful to avoid the very term in his writings, unless cautioning the reader to avoid the idea altogether, lest it be lent too much credibility (McDowell, p. 261). The alternative solution for McDowell is an extension of the natural to describe the thinking and knowing processes simply as "concepts of occurrences and states in our lives," a more liberal Naturalism (McDowell, p. 262). As a side note, I am inclined to think that McDowell's liberal Naturalism would be better described using different terms; at this point, is it really even Naturalism anymore? I believe that, if one takes a Naturalist position, there can be no room for even the slightest bit of liberality, but this is perhaps a topic for another paper. The comparison between McDowell and Lewis is worthy of inspection since both authors recognize the need for something more than simply cause-effect relations to describe human thought processes. In other words, both seem to agree on the simple fact that reason cannot merely be reduced according to natural laws (in McDowell's account) or by meaningless events accumulating into present thought processes (in Lewis's Naturalist account). In conclusion, Lewis's writings in Chapter III provide a strong argument countering Naturalist philosophy. I am compelled by his thorough considerations of the

whole human condition and by his view of man as a creature whose rational faculty runs deeper than merely the result of meaningless external events.